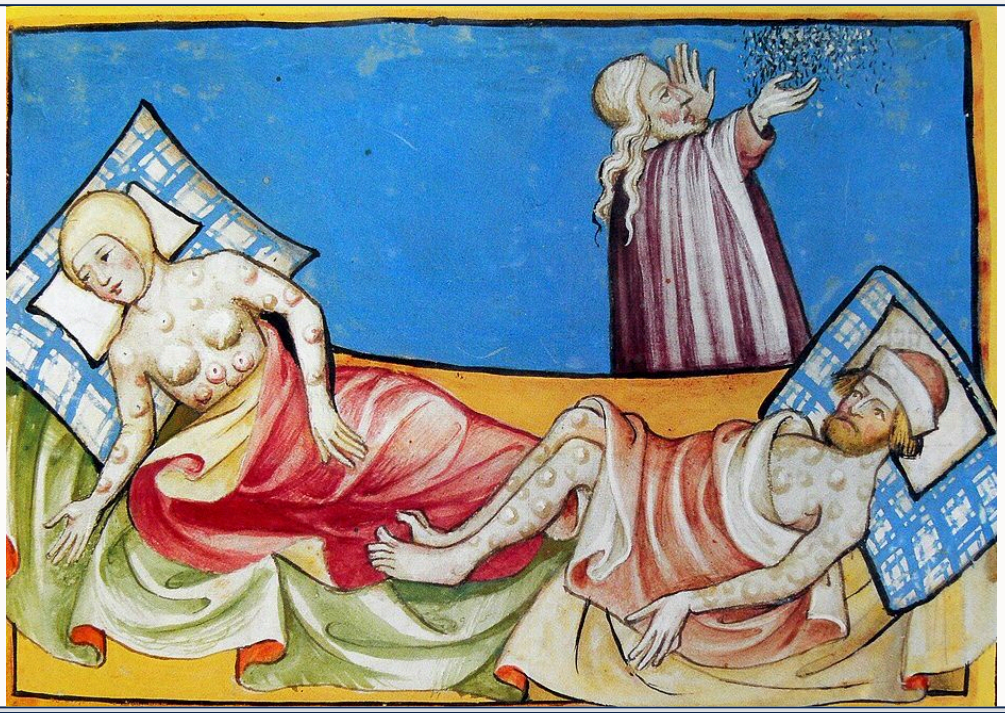
KEY TOPIC 1 • REVISION & PRACTICE COMPANION

Medicine in Medieval Britain, c1250–c1500

Ideas on Causes, Prevention, Treatment, Medical Care & The Black Death



Primary Visual Evidence: *Medieval Plague Sufferers in Bed with Buboes* • Toggenburg Bible MS (1411) CONTEMPORARY PRINT ARCHIVE

PUPIL NAME: _____ TARGET: _____ CLASS: _____

KEY TOPIC 1 SPECIFICATION FRAMEWORK (1HI0/11)	LESSON DONE	QUIZ [10]
Key Topic 1.1: Supernatural & Religious Explanations of Disease *Why did the Catholic Church, scriptoria, and divine retribution dominate medieval understanding of illness?*	☐	☐
Key Topic 1.2: Rational Explanations: Hippocrates, Galen & The Four Humours *Why did the Theory of Opposites, uroscopy wheels, and miasma remain unchallenged for centuries?*	☐	☐
Key Topic 1.3: Approaches to Prevention & Treatment: Rituals, Bleeding & Purging *How did medieval physicians balance fleam bloodletting, treacle theriac, and the Regimen Sanitatis?*	☐	☐
Key Topic 1.4: Medical Care Providers & Monastic Hospitals: 'Care Not Cure' *Who cared for the sick, and why did monastic hospitals prioritize spiritual comfort over medical cure?*	☐	☐
Key Topic 1.5: Case Study: Dealing with the Black Death (1348–1349) *Why was medieval society entirely powerless against the arrival of Yersinia pestis at Melcombe Regis?*	☐	☐

Living Timeline • Part 1: Medieval Ideas & Medical Hierarchy (c1250–c1350)

Living Timeline Dual-Coding Protocol: Complete each milestone sketchpad using dual-coding (combining visual storytelling symbols, causal arrows, and dates) to master the chronological spine across the centre-fold.

c. 1250 • The Church & The Monopoly on Medical Learning

Key Topic 1.1

The Catholic Church controls all English universities (Oxford, Cambridge) and hospital foundations. Monks hand-copy medical manuscripts in scriptoria, preserving Galen's anatomical writings because his teleological view—that the body had a single divine Creator—aligned with Christian dogma.

1277 • The Imprisonment of Roger Bacon

Key Topic 1.1

Franciscan friar and Oxford scholar Roger Bacon is imprisoned by church leaders for heresy after writing that physicians should conduct original scientific experiments rather than blindly copying Galen. This imprisonment effectively halts independent anatomical inquiry for over two centuries.

c. 1300 • The Diagnostic Tools: Matula Flasks & The Zodiac Man

Key Topic 1.2

Physicians practice uroscopy using glass matula flasks, comparing urine colour, density, and smell against 20-shade charts to diagnose humoral imbalance. They carry Vademecum pocketbooks containing the Zodiac Man to determine safe planetary alignments for phlebotomy (bloodletting).

c. 1320 • The Medical Hierarchy: Physicians, Barber-Surgeons & Apothecaries

Key Topic 1.4

A rigid division of medical labour establishes in England. Fewer than 100 elite university-trained physicians diagnose wealthy nobility. Town apothecaries mix theriac and herbal compounds, while lower-status barber-surgeons perform tooth-pulling, wound-cautery, and bloodletting.

Living Timeline Dual-Coding Protocol: Complete each milestone sketchpad using dual-coding (combining visual storytelling symbols, causal arrows, and dates) to master the chronological spine across the centre-fold.

c. 1350 • Monastic Hospitals: The Era of 'Care Not Cure'

Key Topic 1.4

Over 1,200 hospitals run by monks and nuns operate in England (e.g. St Bartholomew's, 1123). Patients receive clean bedding, warmth, food, and continuous prayer facing a chapel altar. Zero surgery or medical cure is attempted; lepers and plague victims are strictly barred.

1345 • The Great Planetary Conjunction in Aquarius

Key Topic 1.5

In March 1345, Mars, Jupiter, and Saturn align in Aquarius. University of Paris physicians state this celestial conjunction drew up poisonous vapours from the earth, corrupting the air with deadly miasma, preparing Europe for the Black Death.

1348 • The Black Death Reaches Melcombe Regis, Dorset

Key Topic 1.5

In June 1348, the pestilence arrives on trade ships carrying black rats and fleas. The dual epidemic—bubonic plague (flea bites, agonizing buboes) and pneumonic plague (airborne coughing droplets)—kills 30–50% of England's population within 18 months.

1349 • King Edward III's Cleanliness Order & East Smithfield Mass Pits

Key Topic 1.5

Alarmed by rotting waste and stench, Edward III orders London streets cleared of dung to remove miasma. Churchyards overflow; emergency mass burial trenches are dug outside city walls at East Smithfield to bury hundreds of corpses daily.

King Edward III ordered Londoners to clean human filth off the streets in 1349. Outstanding for civic smell, totally useless against Yersinia pestis fleas.

Why did the Catholic Church dominate medieval explanations of disease?

Core Specification Focus: Supernatural & religious causes; Catholic Church influence; astrology & planetary conjunctions.

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • 5 CAUSAL MILESTONES

PUPIL NOTE-TAKING ZONE • *Construct concise causal notes alongside each milestone prompt*

1 c1250 · How did church scriptoria prevent new medical ideas from spreading? [1.1]

- **Hand-copying Latin manuscripts by candle-light**
- **Training university priests in Church doctrine**
- **Punishing medical heretics like Roger Bacon**

2 c1280 · Why was leprosy viewed as visible proof of divine judgment? [1.2]

- **Sending sickness to punish human sin**
- **Exiling lepers to isolated Lazar houses**
- **Ringing warning bells in dirt lanes**

3 1345 · How did the Church reconcile astrology with Christian doctrine? [1.3]

- **Consulting parchment zodiac almanac wheels**
- **Aligning Mars, Jupiter, and Saturn in Aquarius**
- **Blaming corrupted night air for fever**

4 c1350 · Why did sick people turn to pilgrimage shrines rather than doctors? [1.4]

- **Lighting beeswax candles before parish shrines**
- **Kissing holy bone relics of saints**
- **Selling paper indulgences to wealthy barons**

5 c1400 · Why did church enforcement of Galen prevent medical progress? [1.5]

- **Treating Galen's pagan texts as sacred truth**
- **Banning human dissections in English towns**
- **Threatening curious scholars with church excommunication**

If you develop a fever in 1300, church logic dictates you definitely committed a sin last Tuesday. Time to buy a pilgrimage badge!

Question 4: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins]

EXTENDED WRITING ASSESSMENT

Explain why the Catholic Church had such a major influence on ideas about the causes of disease in the period c1250–c1500. [12 marks]

Stimulus: Monastic scriptoria and book-copying | The imprisonment of Roger Bacon (1277) *(You must also use information of your own)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

divine retribution • biblical leprosy • Lazar houses • teleology • heresy • Roger Bacon (1277) • monastic scriptoria • 1345 planetary conjunction • astrological almanacs

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.1). In the drawing box, sketch a monk copying Galen's medical book in a scriptorium. Add two speech bubbles explaining why the Church banned new medical experiments and imprisoned Roger Bacon in 1277. **[ ] Done**

Continue your response to Question 4 below:

Final analytical evaluation & concluding historical verdict:

• **QUESTION 3: EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS]** [4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which ideas about the cause of disease in the Medieval period (c1250–c1500) were similar to ideas in the Renaissance period (c1500–c1700). [4 marks]

Why did the Theory of the Four Humours dominate rational medicine for centuries?

Core Specification Focus: Rational explanations: Four Humours (Hippocrates), Theory of Opposites (Galen), Miasma; diagnostic tools.

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • 5 CAUSAL MILESTONES

PUPIL NOTE-TAKING ZONE • *Construct concise causal notes alongside each milestone prompt*

1 c460 BC • How did Hippocrates separate medicine from superstition? [2.1]

- **Rejecting anger of gods at the bedside**
- **Writing case charts on fever symptoms**
- **Swearing ethical oath to protect patients**

2 c1250 • Why did humoral theory seem logical to medieval people? [2.2]

- **Balancing blood, phlegm, and two biles**
- **Linking fluids to four earthly elements**
- **Associating cold damp seasons with winter coughs**

3 c1280 • How did the Theory of Opposites provide practical treatment rules? [2.3]

- **Cooling burning summer fever with cold cucumber**
- **Treating excess phlegm with dry hot pepper**
- **Dissecting Barbary apes to map organs**

4 c1300 • Why did uroscopy give physicians great diagnostic authority? [2.4]

- **Holding glass flasks up to window sunlight**
- **Comparing urine colours against twenty-shade wheels**
- **Sniffing and tasting samples for sweetness**

5 c1350 • Why did rational physicians link bad smells directly to epidemics? [2.5]

- **Fearing stench from open roadside cesspools**
- **Smelling rotting town refuse heaps**
- **Believing toxic smells unbalanced bodily fluids**

Cold and wet? Have some hot dry pepper. Too much blood? Let's slice your arm open. Galen's logic was flawless, provided you survived the cure.

Question 4: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins]

EXTENDED WRITING ASSESSMENT

Explain why the Theory of the Four Humours remained the dominant rational explanation of disease throughout the period c1250–c1500. [12 marks]

Stimulus: Galen's Theory of Opposites | The diagnostic matula (uroscopy) *(You must also use information of your own)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

Four Humours • blood, phlegm, yellow bile, black bile • Theory of Opposites • Galen • clinical observation • Hippocratic Oath • matula • uroscopy wheel • Zodiac Man • miasma

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.2). In the drawing box, sketch a four-part diagram of the Four Humours (Blood, Phlegm, Yellow Bile, Black Bile) showing their seasons and qualities. Annotate Galen's Theory of Opposites alongside a flask of urine. **[ ] Done**

Continue your response to Question 4 below:

Final analytical evaluation & concluding historical verdict:

• QUESTION 3: EXPLAIN ONE DIFFERENCE [4 MARKS] [4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which ideas about the cause of disease in the Medieval period (c1250–c1500) were different from ideas in the Modern period (c1900–present). [4 marks]

How did medieval people attempt to treat and prevent disease, and why did rational and religious methods coexist?

Core Specification Focus: Approaches to treatment and prevention; religious & supernatural treatments; humoral treatments (phlebotomy, purging); herbal remedies; regimens.

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • 5 CAUSAL MILESTONES

PUPIL NOTE-TAKING ZONE • *Construct concise causal notes alongside each milestone prompt*

1 c1250 · Why did ordinary people consider prayer more vital than medicine?	**[3.1]**
• Chanting Latin prayers beside the sickbed	
• Fasting on bread and well water	
• Whipping bare backs to beg God for mercy	

2 c1300 · Why was bloodletting the most universal physical treatment?	**[3.2]**
• Slicing vein walls with iron fleams	
• Applying fat swamp leeches to temples	
• Catching warm dark blood in pewter bowls	

3 c1320 · How was purging believed to restore bodily equilibrium?	**[3.3]**
• Swallowing poisonous black hellebore seeds	
• Pumping warm mallow tea through boar-bladder clysters	
• Emptying bowels to balance bodily humours	

4 c1350 · Why did herbal recipes remain popular across all social classes?	**[3.4]**
• Grinding crushed mint and sage in stone mortars	
• Mixing seventy ingredients into treacle theriac	
• Brewing bitter willow bark teas for fever	

5 c1400 · How did wealthy barons attempt to prevent sickness before it struck?	**[3.5]**
• Following private Latin health rulebooks	
• Burning sweet lavender sticks indoors	
• Carrying fragrant posy flowers through smelly streets	

Bleeding, purging, boiling vinegar, and swallowing crushed emeralds. If the disease didn't kill you, the apothecary's bill definitely would.

Question 4: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins]

Explain why bloodletting and purging remained the most common medical treatments throughout the period c1250–c1500. [12 marks]

Stimulus: Phlebotomy (bloodletting by fleam or leeches) | The Regimen Sanitatis *(You must also use information of your own)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

phlebotomy • fleam • leeches • cupping • purging • emetics • clysters • theriac • herbal materia medica • Regimen Sanitatis • flagellants

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.3). In the drawing box, sketch a barber-surgeon using a fleam and pewter bleeding bowl, alongside a flagellant whip. Label how one treated the body and the other treated the soul. **[ ] Done**

Continue your response to Question 4 below:

Final analytical evaluation & concluding historical verdict:

• QUESTION 3: EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS] [4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which approaches to preventing disease in the Medieval period (c1250–c1500) were similar to approaches in the Renaissance period (c1500–c1700). [4 marks]

Who provided medical care in medieval England, and why did hospitals focus on care rather than cure?

Core Specification Focus: Medical care providers: physicians, apothecaries, barber-surgeons; women in the home; hospitals (monastic care, care not cure).

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • 5 CAUSAL MILESTONES

PUPIL NOTE-TAKING ZONE • *Construct concise causal notes alongside each milestone prompt*

1 c1250 · Why were university physicians accessible only to the ultra-wealthy?	**[4.1]**
• **Studying Latin texts for ten years in Oxford**	
• **Consulting astronomical star charts for baronial clients**	
• **Charging heavy silver fees without touching patients**	

2 c1300 · How did apothecaries provide accessible medicines to townspeople?	**[4.2]**
• **Weighing dried poppy roots on brass scales**	
• **Selling cheap herbal pills to town weavers**	
• **Learning trade secrets through guild apprenticeships**	

3 c1320 · Why were barber-surgeons viewed as lower-status craftsmen?	**[4.3]**
• **Pulling rotten teeth with iron pliers**	
• **Setting broken arm bones with wooden splints**	
• **Cauterising bleeding flesh wounds with red-hot irons**	

4 c1350 · Why did monastic hospitals deliberately avoid medical treatment?	**[4.4]**
• **Sheltering bedridden pilgrims in monastic wards**	
• **Providing warm woollen blankets and fresh vegetable stew**	
• **Hearing Latin mass through chapel chancel screens**	

5 c1400 · Why did the vast majority of sick people rely on female family members?	**[4.5]**
• **Gathering wild chamomile in country hedgerows**	
• **Delivering newborn babies in village cottages**	
• **Applying warm bread poultices to swollen skin**	

Medieval hospitals: clean sheets, warm porridge, 24-hour prayer, and absolutely zero doctors. It was luxury hospitality, not clinical medicine.

Question 4: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins]

Explain why hospital care in medieval England was based on the concept of 'care rather than cure' in the period c1250–c1500. [12 marks]

Stimulus: Monastic rules and religious charity | The exclusion of infectious diseases (lepers and plague victims) *(You must also use information of your own)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

care not cure • monastic hospitals • St Bartholomew's (1123) • infirmarer • university physicians • apothecaries • barber-surgeons • wise women • fleam • Lazar houses

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.4). In the drawing box, sketch the interior of a monastic hospital ward showing rows of beds facing a chapel altar. Annotate why monks prioritized prayer over medical surgery. **[ ] Done**

Barber-surgeons: short back and sides, pull out a molar, lance a boil, amputate a leg. Multi-tasking at its finest and bloodiest.

Continue your response to Question 4 below:

Final analytical evaluation & concluding historical verdict:

• **QUESTION 3: EXPLAIN ONE DIFFERENCE [4 MARKS]** [4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which the work of hospitals in the Medieval period (c1250–c1500) was different from hospitals in the nineteenth century. [4 marks]

Explain the hierarchy: wealthy barons hired Oxford-trained physicians; town merchants visited guild apothecaries; ordinary peasants relied on wise women.

Why did medieval society fail to halt the devastating mortality of the Black Death?

Core Specification Focus: Case study: The Black Death, 1348–49; beliefs about causes; approaches to treatment and prevention; local government action.

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • 5 CAUSAL MILESTONES

PUPIL NOTE-TAKING ZONE • *Construct concise causal notes alongside each milestone prompt*

1 June 1348 · How did trade routes unwittingly bring the plague to England? [5.1]

- **Docking trade cogs from Gascony in Dorset**
- **Unloading flea-infested wool sacks onto wharves**
- **Spreading black rats into crowded timber cottages**

2 Autumn 1348 · Why was the pneumonic strain far deadlier than the bubonic form? [5.2]

- **Swelling agonizing egg-sized groin lumps**
- **Coughing bloody phlegm across family rooms**
- **Killing infected farm labourers within three days**

3 Winter 1348 · Why were medical treatments completely useless against the plague? [5.3]

- **Lancing hard neck swellings with hot knives**
- **Strapping plucked live hens to dark sores**
- **Drinking crushed emerald stones dissolved in vinegar**

4 1349 · How did belief in miasma shape royal prevention orders? [5.4]

- **Ordering town bailiffs to clear butchered animal entrails**
- **Shovelling horse dung out of unpaved London streets**
- **Lighting smoking pitch fires at road corners**

5 1349–1350 · Why did the Black Death trigger a long-term social and economic crisis? [5.5]

- **Digging vast emergency trenches at East Smithfield**
- **Piling stacked corpses under thin river clay**
- **Losing half of England's agricultural workforce**

In 1348, people blamed God, the planets, bad smells, and foreigners. The actual culprits—fleas on black rats—went completely unnoticed.

Question 5/6: Thematic Essay [16 marks + 4 marks SPaG • 25 mins]

EXTENDED WRITING ASSESSMENT

'The main reason why so many people died during the Black Death (1348–49) was because governments had no effective way of preventing disease.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer. [16 marks + 4 marks SPaG]

Stimulus: King Edward III's cleanliness order (1349) | Belief in miasma and supernatural causes | *(You must also use information of your own)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

Black Death (1348) • Melcombe Regis • bubonic plague • pneumonic plague • Yersinia pestis • black rats • Xenopsylla cheopis fleas • buboes • King Edward III • East Smithfield mass graves • miasma

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.5). In the drawing box, sketch the arrival of a trading cog at Melcombe Regis carrying rats and fleas, alongside an emergency mass burial pit at East Smithfield. **[ ] Done**

Continue your response to Question 5/6 below:

Final analytical evaluation & concluding historical verdict:

• QUESTION 3: EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS] [4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which responses to the Black Death (1348–49) were similar to responses to the Great Plague of London (1665). [4 marks]

PUPIL NAME: _____ TARGET: _____ CURRENT GRADE: _____

ENQUIRY	ASSESSMENT COMPONENT FOCUS	PAGE	SCORE	TEACHER COMMENT & NEXT STEPS
KT1.1	**Q4:** Explain Why Church Dominated Explanations c1250–c1500	p. 5–7	/ 12	MARKING FEEDBACK • TARGETS:
	Q3: Explain One Similarity (Causes: Medieval vs Renaissance)	p. 7	/ 4	
KT1.2	**Q4:** Explain Why Four Humours Remained Dominant c1250–c1500	p. 9–11	/ 12	MARKING FEEDBACK • TARGETS:
	Q3: Explain One Difference (Causes: Medieval vs Modern)	p. 11	/ 4	
KT1.3	**Q4:** Explain Why Treatments Focused on Humours & Repentance	p. 13–15	/ 12	MARKING FEEDBACK • TARGETS:
	Q3: Explain One Similarity (Prevention: Medieval vs Renaissance)	p. 15	/ 4	
KT1.4	**Q4:** Explain Why Hospital Care Was Based on 'Care Not Cure'	p. 17–19	/ 12	MARKING FEEDBACK • TARGETS:
	Q3: Explain One Difference (Hospitals: Medieval vs 19th Century)	p. 19	/ 4	
KT1.5	**Q5/6:** Evaluative Essay: Black Death & Government Prevention	p. 21–23	/ 20	MARKING FEEDBACK • TARGETS:
	Q3: Explain One Similarity (Plague Responses: 1348 vs 1665)	p. 23	/ 4	
TOTAL	**Key Topic 1 Cumulative Examination Assessment Portfolio (10 Tasks)**	p. 4–23	/ 88	**Overall Grade:** _____ Teacher Target: _____

• DIGITAL LEARNING & RETRIEVAL HUB • INTERACTIVE LESSONS & QUIZZES — Interactive Textbook • 10 Questions Per Enquiry

KT1.1 Supernatural	KT1.2 Four Humours	KT1.3 Treatments	KT1.4 Hospitals	KT1.5 Black Death
LESSON HUB	LESSON HUB	LESSON HUB	LESSON HUB	LESSON HUB
PRACTICE QUIZ	PRACTICE QUIZ	PRACTICE QUIZ	PRACTICE QUIZ	PRACTICE QUIZ
Score: [/ 10]	Score: [/ 10]	Score: [/ 10]	Score: [/ 10]	Score: [/ 10]

Superstition, humours, and herbal mixtures gave way to observation; retrieval practice will guarantee your GCSE exam success.